

The carpet, a symphony of glowing colors executed with unsurpassed artistry and fantastic in its detail, is generally acknowledged to be one of the two finest carpets in the Western world.

The Ardabil sold for \$27,000 in 1910. Nine years later, it was purchased by the famous art expert—dealer Lord Duveen, who paid \$57,000 for it. I bought the carpet from Lord Duveen in 1938, paying him \$68,000. I subsequently received many offers for the Ardabil, including one of \$250,000 from Egypt's then-King Farouk. I declined his offer along with all the others. In 1958, the Los Angeles County Museum—to which I had donated the carpet—

placed its value at \$1,000,000, almost 40 times the price for which it had been sold in 1910 and nearly 15 times what I had paid for it.

In the same year that I bought the Ardabil carpet, I also acquired the fine Rembrandt portrait of Marten Looten, which the great Dutch master had painted in 1632. I paid \$65,000 for the picture and considered it a bargain, for I had been quite prepared to go as high as \$100,000 to obtain it. The market value of the painting increased fantastically through the years. How much it would fetch at a sale today is a purely academic question, for the portrait was also donated to the Los Angeles County Museum. However, the record \$2,300,000 paid for Rembrandt's *Aristotle*

Contemplating the Bust of Homer would seem to

234

indicate that *Marten Looten* would bring a price many times greater than what I paid for it.¹

But one does not have to buy the works of acknowledged old masters to obtain fine works of art—or, for that matter, to make excellent investments.

For example, the Spanish artist Joaquin Sorolla y Bastida lived from 1893 to 1923. In 1933, I attended an art sale in New York City, saw some of his work and thought it excellent. I bought ten of Sorolla y Bastida's paintings for a total of well under \$10,000. By 1938, the world had begun to really